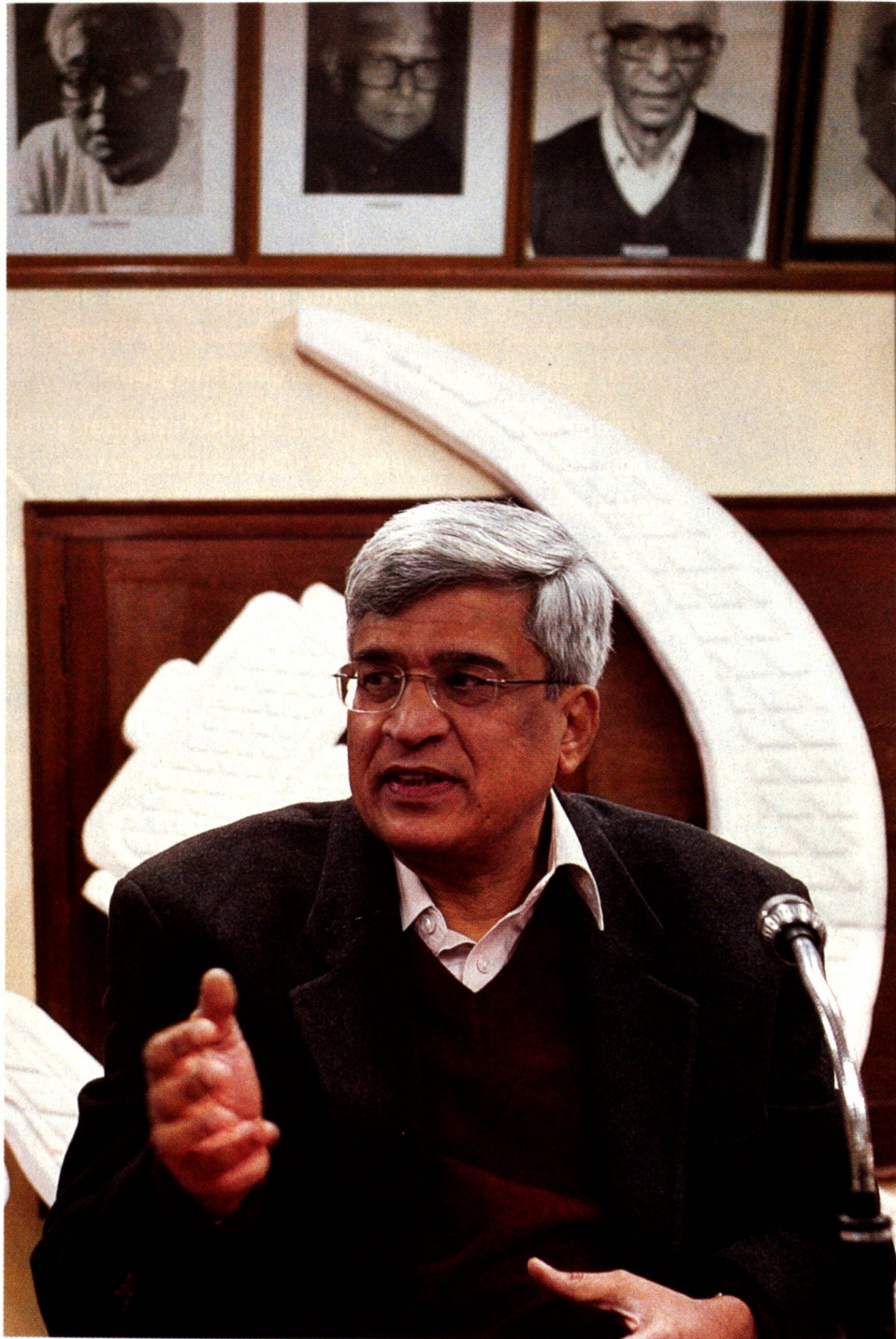


"We are looking for a third alternative"

CPI(M) General Secretary Prakash Karat is the quintessential Dr Dogma. Unrelenting, he is prepared to spend yet another year arguing against the Indo-US nuclear agreement, but will not yield an inch more to the Government. Last week, Karat spoke to Editor PRABHU CHAWLA and Principal Correspondent SATARUPA BHATTACHARYA. Not exactly the bite-friendly politician, Karat played it safe and was politically correct. He chose his words and the questions. While he responded to questions on the Left's disengagement with the Congress on the nuclear deal, he refused to answer queries on Prime Minister Manmohan Singh and Congress President Sonia Gandhi or on when he sees the next polls being held. On the defensive when speaking on Nandigram, his party's moment of shame, Karat declined to respond to the allegation that his party practised politics in Delhi and economics in West Bengal. Excerpts from the interview.

Q. A majority in Parliament are against the nuclear deal in its present form. But the Congress has gone to the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA). Is it being unreasonable?

A. The discussion in Parliament has clearly established that a majority of MPs in both Houses are opposed to the 123 Agreement in some way or the other. The other issue is that of the talks with IAEA on the India-specific safeguards agreement. The UPA-Left committee agreed that the Government will hold talks with IAEA and the outcome would be presented to the committee for consideration. Since this was a joint decision, we cannot say the Congress is being unreasonable. Considering the Parliament's views, however, it will be better for the Government to not



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